bring one Mohammad to Delhi and he admitted that he had even helped this Mohammad to buy a car. But he has also maintained that he did not know any of the other four men who actually attacked Parliament.

Afzal's family has good reason to be afraid of the STF.

Mohammad Afzal comes from a very poor family. His father died when he was young and his elder brother, Aijaz, brought him up. Aijaz himself could not study very much but he supported his younger brother who had a passion for learning and wanted to be a doctor. It was Afzal's dream and Aijaz supported him.

Afzal was in his first year of MBBS when the youth in Kashmir rose up in revolt against the farcical elections of 1987 when the candidates who had won were put into jails and those who had betrayed their people were put in the assembly. It was a tidal wave of resistance to decades of oppression. The processions in the Valley were kilometres long. The youth in their thousands gave up their dreams of secure careers and the warmth of their homes and crossed steep, dangerous icy passes to take armed training in Pakistan Occupied Kashmir (POK). Afzal was one of them.

However, he came back after three months because he was disillusioned by the fact that Pakistan too was using Kashmiris for its narrow politics. He returned and surrendered to the Border Security Force. The condition of surrender is that the militant has to motivate two others also to surrender and he did that as well.

Afzal got a job selling medical and surgical instruments. It was the closest to his dream of becoming a doctor. He earned some five thousand rupees a month and he got married. Two days after his marriage, the STF men came to his home and took him to their camp. They kept him there for nearly a month and every day he was brutally tortured. They poured petrol into his anus, they kept him in freezing water and they beat him.

The family managed to rescue him only after they raised one lakh rupees to satisfy the greed of the STF who are known to be extortionists. Tabassum, a new bride, sold all her jewellery, his mother sold his scooter and finally Afzal was handed back more dead than alive. No one in the family can forget the terror of those days.

Aijaz is wild with fear that the STF will pick him up if Afzal expose's the STF. The irony is that Aijaz seems to have more faith in the media and Indian democratic institutions than is merited by the facts. Despite the fact that Mufti Saeed came to power in Kashmir with the promise to dismantle the STF, and